# 4

# Manic

GEORGE FLOYD WAS ARRESTED for allegedly using a counterfeit twenty-dollar bill to buy cigarettes on May 25, 2020, in Minneapolis, Minnesota. The senior officer in command, Derek Chauvin, knelt on his neck for over nine minutes, ultimately killing him. Floyd was calling for help as he took his last breaths. Many tried to portray him as having overdosed, even though the amounts of fentanyl and methamphetamine in his system were not enough to cause death.[1] Conservative media described Floyd as "hysterical," "on drugs," and "a lunatic."[2]

While police knelt on Floyd, the rookie officer, Thomas Lane, is heard on body camera footage asking whether this might be a case of "excited delirium."[3] During the trial, Chauvin's defense attorneys argued that excited delirium syndrome was real and that Chauvin's lethal force was justified because of Floyd's superhuman strength.[4] Initially, when George Floyd's death was addressed on the Minneapolis Police Department website, the narrative was in line with a medical defense. It stated, "Man Dies after Medical Incident during Police Interaction."[5] The post described Floyd's death as follows:

> Officers were able to get the suspect into handcuffs and noted he appeared to be suffering medical distress. Officers called for an ambulance. He was transported to Hennepin County Medical Center by ambulance where he died a short time later.
>
> At no time were weapons of any type used by anyone involved in this incident.[6]

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Initially, the official police statement reassured the public that officers were assisting Floyd. There was a false impression that Floyd just spontaneously died within a short time of interacting with police. If seventeen-year-old Darnella Frazier had not posted her bystander video to Facebook showing Officer Chauvin kneeling on Floyd's neck, the world might never have known that this was far from a person suffering medical distress—rather, it was a public lynching.

As a result of Floyd's death, people started looking into excited delirium syndrome. The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) and the American Civil Liberties Union (ACLU) argued that excited delirium serves as a medical scapegoat for police abuse and is not an actual medical diagnosis. The syndrome is not listed in the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* (*DSM*-5) and has no International Classification of Diseases (ICD-9 or ICD-10) code, which means that it cannot be studied statistically as a diagnosis. It is also not recognized by the American Medical Association (AMA), the American Psychiatric Association (APA), or the World Health Organization.[7] However, it is recognized by the National Association of Medical Examiners, which allows for it to be used as a legitimate cause of death in the United States.[8] *CBS News* reported in 2018 that a review of studies found that more than 10 percent of deaths in police custody that year were attributed to excited delirium.[9] The way the US medical system presumes a diagnosis to be stable when it is not is part of how this so-called syndrome has hidden in plain sight for so long.

* * *

In November 2021, the police contacted Jade Ellis and requested that she retrieve the ashes of her father, Jeremy, which had been discovered by a police officer in a random hotel in San Diego. Bewildered by how her father's ashes ended up in the hotel, Jade, who was listed as his next of kin, received the call to collect them. Jade felt a sense of irritation, expressing her reluctance to embark on the two-hour drive, still harboring resentment toward her dad. She recalled saying, "I was like, 'Oh, hell no. I don't want them.'"

The police told Jade Ellis's family that Jeremy was "on drugs" and that he had died because of heart failure attributable to excited delirium syndrome. Jade remembers them saying he just "up and died." For years, Jade had been upset with her dad for the way he had died. She blamed him for leaving her. Even so, despite her initial reluctance, she eventually made the journey to retrieve the ashes.

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During that period, Jade was deeply immersed in preparing for her initiation to Santeria. Her guiding orisha is Obatala, known for embodying tranquility and revered as the elder among the orishas. While Obatala typically presents as male, they are among the few orisha who transcend traditional gender roles, manifesting as male, female, and nonbinary genders depending on the moral narrative revealed through divination. Jade's Obatala was determined to be feminine through the cowry-shell oracle (*dillogún*). Being initiated to the orisha of eldership was ironic for Jade, given that many people in her hometown of East Los Angeles, rarely have the privilege of growing old. For instance, Jeremy, who was killed at the age of forty, was considered "old" by neighborhood standards.

Jade told me that her father's spirit was "buggin' lately."

Jeremy had been trying to get her attention, but she had been deliberately avoiding his attempts at communication. Since his death, Jade had learned how to keep Jeremy's pesky spirit at arm's length when she decided to stop "doing him" and be herself. Her journey from wounded child to liberation artist had not been easy. Now an activist, a tattoo artist, a poet, and a soon-to-be priestess, she had endured so much pain and hardship to get to where she was. I was glad Obatala would bring Jade some much-deserved peace.

I suspected that Jeremy's spirit may have become more active because of Jade's upcoming initiation ceremonies. Practitioners of my traditions understand the spirit plane (*ará onú*) as a site where spiritual entities can become more powerful, "developed" (*desarollado*) in death. Through Jade's ceremonies, Jeremy's spirit would be "activated," allowing for more direct interaction with Jade and her spiritual family—even with me. These concepts align with theories of quantum physics that question the fixed nature of matter and have long recognized the interconnectedness of the world through waves, energies, particles, transmissions, and imperceptible forces.[10]

I asked Jade what she knew about how Jeremy had died. She really did not know much. She had been informed that there was a police pursuit, and that Jeremy's heart "stopped" during the incident. To gather further details, Jade connected me with her mother, Carmen.

I felt an immediate bond with Carmen during our phone conversation. Her affection for Jade and Jeremy resonated in her voice. According to Carmen, Jeremy came across as a good listener, but he did not really engage in extensive conversation. He had gained a reputation for illegally acquiring old cars, and his friends would call on him for special orders. Jade had shared with me



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that there were typically "five cars in rotation" when Jeremy was around. He would refurbish and customize lowriders, selling some and giving others away to spread happiness through the neighborhood. It was his way of beautifying the community, a form of extralegal community art.

Carmen reminisced about meeting him at a lowrider show. Describing "Big Jer" as "the love of my life," with his tall stature, dark complexion, and charming smile, she was immediately taken by his good looks and gentle demeanor.

Jeremy grew up in the heart of "gang land," as Carmen described it; "there was lots of crime and shoot-outs." His mother, Diane, a biracial woman with a Black father and a White mother, gave birth to Jeremy during her eleventh-grade year, at the age of seventeen. Jeremy's father, Marcel, a Black German man, was not around in his life. Diane's struggle with heroin addiction began when Jeremy was young, leading him to be raised primarily by his White grandmother, Bev. Jeremy's aunties, Brenda and Glenda, also resided in the house and were involved in the family business of "boosting," or theft.

According to Carmen, "they were all boosters." Jeremy had told Carmen that while growing up, he recalled having cold packs of frozen meat in his stroller as his mother shoplifted from grocery stores. Bev, his White grandmother, was known for her constant companions: her shotgun, a cup of coffee, and her Pall Mall cigarettes. In one memorable family tale, Grandma Bev was sitting in her favorite spot, a La-Z-Boy recliner on the porch, when a drive-by shooting took place. A bullet pierced her coffee cup, prompting her to calmly say "Get 'em," and everyone in her house rushed out with their guns.

Carmen also fondly recalled Jeremy's aspirations to be a good father to Jade and her sister, Eva. She proudly noted that they had carefully planned both children, ensuring that they were "exactly seven years apart." Carmen wanted a family, and especially children, with Jeremy. "It was fucked up," she remembered of the hurt she saw in Jeremy's eyes when he couldn't be there for their kids. He had not wanted to repeat his parents' mistakes. They often discussed the need to "get our shit together" now that they were parents. Jade's birth—Carmen was convinced the baby would be a girl—marked a significant moment in their lives. Carmen even chuckled about how she had accurately predicted her trans daughter's gender.

Jade holds cherished memories of the times Jeremy was around. Despite being an awkward queer kid, she never faced harassment in her neighborhood because her father was highly respected. "A lot of my safety I owe to that, I

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think," she says. "I was never bullied nor mistreated by my community. At least not for being gay." Jade's newfound Santeria community is also rallying behind her, recognizing the love and positivity she brings to the world. When we met, the *ile* (house-temple) was generously covering the costs for her initiation ceremonies, which amounted to several thousand dollars and encompassed all the necessary items for the rituals.

When Jeremy passed away on June 11, 2011, he had spent a significant portion of Jade's life in and out of prison. At the time of his death, Jeremy was on parole and had accumulated two prior strikes under California's "Three Strikes and You're Out" law, which meant he would face a life sentence if he were arrested once more. Before he died, his plan was to return to Carmen and the kids, and he had scheduled a date with them on Father's Day. Carmen recounted the circumstances surrounding his death as she had been told: "The police are behind him on the freeway. He knows he's going to go to jail for life. Somehow, they crashed into him. The police didn't do it correctly. They made him crash, and he hit a big semi. Him being on crystal, they said his heart goes out. He crashes into the semi-truck." While she couldn't recall the specific freeway, she remembered that it had made the news. "It was a big car chase," Carmen shared.

"Did they conduct an autopsy?" I inquired.

"No," she replied. "We were just told his heart went out, and he died. That it was unexplainable."

During my conversation with Carmen, I sensed Jeremy's spirit. The atmosphere shifted, and I felt an urgency, as if he wanted me to pay attention to something.

"They made him crash," Carmen asserted. "They made him hit that semi. And they told us his heart failed." It was clear to me that Jeremy deemed this information significant. I could discern his desire for me to include it in the book.

The coroner officially recorded Jeremy's death as "unclassified." Families often receive vague explanations regarding the cause of death. It is occasionally attributed to heart failure and commonly labeled as "unclassified" or "undetermined." Medical examiners across the country use excited delirium syndrome as either the cause of death or as contributing to death, and they attribute the syndrome to some kind of drug-related heart failure. In addition to cocaine, it is now associated with the use of methamphetamine. Medical examiners will usually opt for an "unclassified" designation if they believe further investigation is necessary. Jeremy's death, however, remained



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uninvestigated. It was only eight years after his passing, following the death of George Floyd, that people started to seriously question the syndrome that police claimed led to his demise.

* * *

In the weeks that followed, I reached out to Jade and told her about the information I had learned from her mother regarding her father's death. Jade was taken aback. "I remember them trying to say my dad was manic and just crazy," she said, referring to the police's characterization of him. "They made him seem like he was drugged out—out of control—and he just died."

Jade's observation is quite accurate, as there exists a historical connection between excited delirium syndrome and the medicalization of mania. In my research on Charles Wetli, I uncovered that he, along with a coauthor, coined the term *excited delirium syndrome* in 1985. Although Wetli and his coauthors would later expand their hypothesis to encompass other drugs, including methamphetamine, their initial focus was primarily on cocaine. In his capacity as the deputy chief medical examiner for Dade County, Wetli collaborated on two articles with his colleague David A. Fishbain, a psychiatrist who supervised the psychiatric emergency services at Jackson Memorial Hospital in Miami, and held an associate professorship at the University of Miami School of Medicine during that period.[11] These two articles laid the foundation for what is now recognized as "excited delirium syndrome."[12]

The articles identified a range of symptoms they claimed were induced by cocaine, including disorientation, hallucinations, disturbed perceptions, impaired thinking, and other manifestations of "delirium." The authors argued that these symptoms resulted from low-level drug toxicity and purportedly led to the death of people in police custody. In 1985, Fishbain and Wetli coined the term *excited delirium syndrome* based on a study of seven cases of people who died between April 1983 and May 1984.[13] To establish a precedent for excited delirium syndrome, Fishbain and Wetli referred to the experiments conducted by Dr. Luther Bell in 1847 at the McLean Asylum for the Insane in Somerville, Massachusetts.

During the Mexican-American War, a number of unexpected deaths occurred among Dr. Bell's hospitalized patients when he conducted experiments on them. The first individual, a thirty-five-year-old woman identified as "E.A.P.," whose husband was serving in the war, was described as "wildly attacking" anyone who approached her.[14] The asylum documented E.A.P.'s display of "mania" and "delirium."[15] She was restrained in a bed, administered

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small doses of opium, and subjected to leeching for sixteen days. According to medical records, she remained in a state of high excitement, recognizing no one, rarely sleeping, and experiencing diarrhea.[16] The following day, she was described as having "suddenly" passed away. Several similar deaths occurred at the asylum, where Dr. Bell treated patients in like manner—restraining them in beds, applying leeches, and administering opium. Bell documented forty such unexplained deaths between 1836 and 1849, describing the deceased individuals as exhibiting symptoms of "acute exhaustive mania" and "agitated delirium," characterized by "sleeplessness, disconnected delusions, and hallucinations," ultimately culminating in unexplained death.[17] Bell published his findings in the *American Journal of Insanity* in October 1849, and this phenomenon became known as "Bell's mania" or "excited catatonia."

This diagnosis fascinated me. As I kept looking, I discovered that the history of mania is intertwined with the criminalization of spiritualists in the nineteenth century. At the time when Dr. Bell conducted his experiments leading to the coining of the term *Bell's mania*, medical doctors were not universally regarded as all-knowing experts. Healing practices of the era were influenced by a multitude of cultural traditions, with Western doctors vying for prominence. Even scientists in the United States in the 1860s did not dismiss the notion of spirits.[18] Alfred Russel Wallace, who alongside Charles Darwin proposed the theory of evolution, was among those who believed "that spirit communications" validated the existence "of an extracorporeal dimension" to human beings.[19]

However, as doctors sought to establish themselves as the sole authorities on health and medicine, they viewed spiritualists as a threat. A network of physicians, particularly neuroscientists claiming expertise in the understanding of the mind, launched a campaign against spiritual mediums.[20] They labeled spiritualists lunatics and swindlers, contending that spiritualism constituted mental illness, manifesting as neuroses, mania, delirium, and even insanity.[21] They introduced a new disorder known as "medio mania," which posited that mediumship trances resulted from an abnormality in the "upper part of the cerebrum."[22] They even suggested that this condition could be contagious among "séance goers" with "a similar occult deficiency of the nervous system."[23] Medio mania was predominantly seen as a neurotic disorder affecting women, associated with vegetarian diets and uterine issues, although doctors believed that men could also exhibit these symptoms by purportedly mimicking women's behavior.[24] Treatment for this "disorder" typically involved a combination of sedatives, tonics, high-protein diets, and the application of electricity to bodies.[25]



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The criminalization of female spiritualists was a direct result of their refusal to conform to the prevailing societal norms for White women's domestication and their challenge to positivist scientific thinking.[26] Police, doctors, lawyers, and politicians targeted spiritualists and fortune tellers with sting operations, lawsuits, and accusations of lunacy. Spiritualists were declared legally insane, leading to the confiscation of their properties and disputes over their wills.[27] By 1893, the National Spiritualists Association (today the National Spiritualist Association of Churches) was formed to defend healers and mediums across the country who were charged with crimes.[28]

Anyone who acknowledged visions—even subconscious ones—was a threat. During the same period, even psychologists faced a reputation as "mad doctors," with skepticism surrounding their therapeutic methods, a stigma that persists to this day. In an effort to counter the perception of irrationality, psychologists embarked on a reform movement targeting individuals who did not conform to neurological models of the mind.[29] Between 1860 and 1875, a coalition of neuroscientists, criminologists, physicians, and psychologists in the United States and Britain joined forces to criminalize spiritual healers and elevate Western medicine as the sole authority in the field. This concerted effort led to a broader cultural shift, in which those claiming contact with spirits were branded as insane.

This systematic criminalization of spiritualism extended to Afro-Latiné religions, and criminologists emphasized the importance of reinforcing Western medicine to uphold White values and prevent what they deemed "racial degeneration."[30] Prominent criminological eugenicists such as Cesar Lombroso, often referred to as the "father of positivist criminology," were instrumental in targeting spiritualists through his research in prisons and asylums.[31] Lombroso, who subscribed to the belief that criminality was hereditary, influenced his student Fernando Ortiz, who later became renowned as the father of the study of Afro-Cuban religions. In his first book, *Afro-Cuban Underworld: The Black Witches* (*El hampa Afro-Cubana: Los Negros brujos*), Ortiz argued that an African "germ of homicide remains latent" in Black people, waiting to be awakened through savage rituals.[32] Although Ortiz later apologized for this racist criminology, it nevertheless contributed to the criminalization of Afro-Latiné religions for generations.

It is not the first time that medical doctors would weaponize mental illnesses like mania as a way to criminalize non-White and nonconforming people. But I was surprised to discover that Wetli and his coauthors had joined Bell's mania with their own blend of American eugenics.



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Even when it became evident in 1989 that the Black women whose deaths Charles Wetli had erroneously labeled "cocaine-sex deaths" had, in reality, been victims of murder, he staunchly clung to the belief that Black people possessed a genetic predisposition to become "cocaine-crazed" and to spontaneously die around police. Building on his earlier claims about the cardiac arrest of the Black basketball star Len Bias, Wetli maintained his argument that young Black males were at a heightened risk of death from cocaine.[33] Thus, according to Wetli and other medical practitioners who worked closely with police, cocaine would be the ready explanation for the deaths of Black males in the midst of violent encounters with law enforcement.

However, I was taken aback to uncover that in a 1996 article published in the *American Journal of Emergency Medicine*, Wetli and coauthors had referenced a racist news report from 1914, which had been used to justify lynchings during that era.[34] In note 2 of "Cocaine-Associated Agitated Delirium and the Neuroleptic Malignant Syndrome," Wetli and his colleagues cited a *New York Times* article, written by Dr. Edward Huntington Williams, that warned of "negro cocaine 'fiends'" causing havoc in the South.[35] Wetli and his colleagues used this citation as historical support for their claim that Black people exhibit extreme reactions to small amounts of cocaine.

Historians have demonstrated that accounts like Dr. Williams's were prevalent during the Reconstruction period, when Ku Klux Klan (KKK) patrols and police collaborated to maintain White social dominance.[36] Cocaine use became directly associated with Black men during this period. Southern segregationists and northern physicians, including individuals like Dr. Williams, collaborated to promote anticocaine measures, ultimately leading to a national ban on the substance in 1914.[37] The stringent crackdown on the drug served to criminalize Black men and justify White mob violence and the arming of law enforcement with guns.[38] Concerns surrounding cocaine reinforced the stereotype that African Americans were violent, uncivilized, and uncontrollable.[39] Such racially biased narratives fueled terror campaigns against Black people in the South, prompting the "Great Migration" (1910–70) of African Americans to northern cities.

The article cited by Wetli and his colleagues bore the sensational title "NEGRO COCAINE 'FIENDS' ARE A NEW SOUTHERN MENACE; Murder and Insanity Increasing among Lower Class Blacks Because They Have Taken to 'Sniffing' Since Deprived of Whisky by Prohibition."[40] This article depicted southern Black people in fantastical scenarios, portraying them as lascivious



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individuals engaged in "cocaine orgies," "sniffing parties," and "wholesale murder."[41]

The article's author recounted an incident in which the Asheville chief of police killed a Black man in his own home. The man was reportedly under the influence of cocaine, and instead of subduing him, the police chief beat him to death. Dr. Williams tells us that the chief first tried to shoot the man to "kill him right quick." When the man did not immediately succumb, the chief resorted to beating him to death, all while his family and community members looked on in horror. Dr. Williams noted that, in case the family considered aiding the Black man, the police chief had conserved his ammunition for the impending "mob."

The article concluded with Williams's plea for increased armament of the police. He argued that law enforcement needed more potent weapons to counter Black men under the influence of cocaine, as firearms capable of killing "any game in America" were insufficient to halt "the increased vitality of the cocaine-crazed negroes."[42] Dr. Williams cautioned White readers about the sinister impact of cocaine on Black people:

> The list of dangerous effects produced by cocaine just described—hallucinations and delusions, increased courage, homicidal tendencies, resistance to shock—is certainly long enough. But there is still another, and a most important one. This is a temporary steadying of the nervous and muscular system, so as to increase, rather than interfere with good marksmanship.[43]

Echoing the historical rationales for slavery and colonization, the age-old myth of Black superhuman strength was resurrected not only to justify police killings but also to promote a heightened vigilance around Black people. For Dr. Williams would also have us believe that Black people on cocaine somehow gain a new superpower: they become expert marksmen, too.

Penned by a White physician, this *New York Times* article serves as a stark illustration of the close relationship between police violence, medical justification, and lynching. It was the Black investigative journalist Ida B. Wells who initially exposed how southern lynch mobs incited widespread fear through displays of violence against Black men. In her 1892 pamphlet *Southern Horrors*, Wells adeptly demonstrates the connections between the lynching of Black men by White mobs and sexual violence against Black women by White men. She used the term *Southern horrors* to mock the commonly cited pretext for lynching Black men, alleging that they had assaulted White

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women.[44] Wells illustrated how the portrayal of Black men as rapists effectively placed them "beyond the pale of human sympathy."[45] She further revealed how lynching was employed as a smoke screen to disguise Whites' violent efforts to strip African Americans of their hard-fought rights.[46]

Wells's subsequent book, *A Red Record: Tabulated Statistics and Alleged Causes of Lynchings in the United States, 1892–1893–1894*, published in 1894, meticulously utilized White newspapers to document more than ten thousand lynchings of African Americans, shedding light on the role of media dissemination in instilling fear among readers. Just as in Dr. Williams's article, news media portrayed Black men as "beasts" and served as an endorsement for lynching.[47] Lynching is as much about White spectatorship as it is about racial violence. Historian Amy Louise Woods elucidates how the White audience played an integral role in the mechanics of lynching.[48] As a ritual, lynching consolidated White supremacy by leveraging the wide circulation of lynching stories and imagery. Lynching was not only about the violent act itself; it was also a media campaign that united White viewers through a shared perception of Black threat. The widespread dissemination of lynching images, depicting White power and Black denigration, served to "instill and perpetuate a sense of racial supremacy in their White spectators."[49]

* * *

This legacy of lynching in medical racism persists, often obscuring systemic violence and perpetuating harmful stereotypes. In their 1996 article, Wetli and his colleagues cite Dr. Edward Huntington Williams's argument that Black people had a predisposition to becoming "frenzied" and wild with "mania" when using cocaine, thereby reinforcing their racially biased genetic argument. [50] This citation serves as a disconcerting example of how racist ideas are entrenched in medical science—effectively resurrecting the narrative of lynching media.

One thing I found curious after discovering Dr. Williams's 1914 article was that it does not actually describe a precedent for excited delirium syndrome, as Wetli and colleagues suggest in their citation. At no point does Dr. Williams make the claim that Black people unexpectedly die in police custody. His account instead describes a police officer openly assassinating a Black man who was believed to exhibit superhuman strength.

The narratives like those of the "Negro Cocaine 'Fiends'" provide a platform for White doctors like Edward Williams to assert control over the moral safety of White America. Wetli employed a similar strategy when he classi-



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fied the murdered Black women as suffering "cocaine-sex deaths." In his own words, Wetli was steadfast in his belief that the Black "species" possessed a racial-genetic predisposition to cocaine that led to their deaths in police custody. Much like Fernando Ortiz's notion of an African "germ" of criminality, Wetli's eugenicist perspective was veiled behind his scientific discourse. Like Dr. Williams, Wetli and his colleagues propagated the notion that cocaine bestowed Blacks with seemingly superhuman strength, especially when confronted by law enforcement.[51] This perceived superhuman strength, in their view, served as a justification for excessive police force.

Rejecting the argument that police restraint or "positional asphyxia" could result in fatalities, Wetli and his colleagues contended that it might be "tempting" to attribute the cause of death to "minor injuries" sustained during police encounters, "such as minor head injury," but they argued that this would lead to unnecessary lawsuits.[52] Defending police violence as "normal procedure" against agitated, coked-out Black people, Wetli and colleagues claimed that the deaths of those with excited delirium syndrome should *always* be attributed to cocaine toxicity, even though some individuals classified as having had the syndrome had "low to modest cocaine blood levels and [did] not behave like patients with massive overdose."[53]

I think about fourteen-year-old Antoinette Burns and twenty-three-year-old Barbara Ann Black, who were raped and murdered with no cocaine in their systems. Yet Wetli labeled their deaths as instances of spontaneous heart failure attributed to "cocaine-sex." His argument concerning the relationship between cocaine-induced delirium and police restraint bears a disconcerting resemblance. He did discern a pattern in police-involved deaths. For example, Wetli and colleagues asserted, "Shortly after being restrained, agitation ceases and the victim is frequently found dead, or near death, just moments later."[54] Indeed, the authors were aware of the role that police violence played in deaths attributed to excited delirium syndrome. In anticipation of this criticism, they stood firm, asserting: "Since the victims frequently die in police custody, there are often allegations that death resulted from asphyxia related to hogtying, or other police procedures such as restraining neck hold, pepper sprays, or electrical stun devices. However, it is important to note that many victims of this disorder die suddenly and without the application of any law enforcement restraining techniques."[55]

Consequently, the authors swiftly rejected the evidence that police violence could be responsible for deaths they attribute to excited delirium syndrome. "When cocaine users with agitated delirium die, cocaine should be considered

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the cause of death,"[56] the authors state unequivocally. "It is well to remember that in most cases of agitated delirium, death occurs without significant police restraint, and frivolous speculation about the cause or mechanisms of death will only invite needless litigation."[57]

If Wetli had been the medical examiner in George Floyd's case, he would likely have attributed Floyd's death to excited delirium syndrome. I must admit that I continually find myself surprised by these revelations. While I am not oblivious to the role of systemic racism, I am deeply concerned about the extensive influence of medical categorization and diagnosis in concealing this violence. Diagnoses such as medio mania, which criminalized spiritualists, and excited delirium, which targets Black and Latiné people, are not rooted in objective facts. As I observed from Wetli's cited precedents (Bell's mania and "negro cocaine 'fiends'"), these are fictitious medical conditions that only masquerade as truth. It is the underpinning of racial science that enables them to function as seemingly impartial classifications.

Psychiatrist Jonathan Metzl exposes this process in action, illustrating how racism has been ingrained in diagnostic language throughout history.[58] For instance, eugenicist social scientists in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries crafted flawed social studies to substantiate the biological supremacy of White races and the inferiority of Black and Brown races.[59] In the "Black extinction hypothesis," statistician Fredrick Hoffman utilized 1890 census data in his book *The Race Traits and Tendencies of the American Negro* (1896) to depict African Americans as highly susceptible to disease, and argued that "their extinction was inevitable."[60] Rather than attributing the shorter life expectancy among Black people to systemic inequality and racist violence,[61] Hoffman, as Erickson relates, reduced his findings to "a simple tautology": Black people "died because they were inferior," and they were considered "inferior because they died."[62]

What I've learned from this history is that while medical categories may appear stable, I do not take for granted that diagnoses are constantly being contested.[63] In the case of diagnosing syndromes, Western medical practitioners rely on individuals' descriptions of their bodily experiences, diagnosing based on reported "symptoms."[64]

I think about the story I traced of how mania leads to excited delirium. However, with excited delirium syndrome, medical examiners "work backward" in identifying the cause of death, as no specific disease can be diagnosed through autopsy. Instead, medical examiners rely on the accounts of police officers and paramedics regarding the behaviors exhibited by the deceased to



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attribute the cause of death. Since the dead person cannot speak, at least not in a way recognizable to Western medicine, the distinction between classifying someone's death as excited delirium syndrome or as a homicide is often simply what police officers and paramedics report happened at the scene. Yet, by telling this story through the lens of the victims' experiences, as the Combahee River Collective advises, we unveil how these medical diagnoses are little more than racially biased conjectures bolstered by the authority of medical examiners and the law enforcement apparatus that depends on them.

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JOURNAL ENTRY

## Wednesday, October 13, 2021
Emerald Hills, California

*When the dead visit my dreams, I can't hear their voices, but I can sense their intentions. It's not like that for everyone. But that's how it is for me. That's how it was when my stepson, Sito, visited me. He didn't speak with his voice, but he showed me what he wanted me to know.*

*I still can't believe Sito passed. He was taken from us on September 8, 2019, at the age of nineteen. It is an unimaginable loss. When he was fourteen, he had witnessed the tragic stabbing of a fellow student, a Black Latino boy from the Mission whom Sito had known for many years. Then, Sito was arrested and falsely accused of the boy's stabbing. Even though the police knew Sito was not the killer, he spent four months incarcerated in maximum security at San Francisco's Juvenile Hall, a place notorious for its violence. This experience forever impacted our family and ultimately led to Sito's revenge murder only a few short years later. Sito's story is a different side of the tragic cycle of youth violence and inner-city police corruption. My husband, Laurence, is writing a book about Sito's story. I feared that I couldn't.*

*Sito is one of the spirits guiding me through my process of uncovering the evidence in this book. At the funeral, his friends said he'd become their guardian angel. Right before his death, Sito had begun the process to be initiated as a*

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*priest of Santeria. And even though his ceremony was not completed, Sito is still a powerful copresence. He guides and protects us.*

*Neto told me that Sito is the reason he decided to start helping people after George Floyd's death. Sito wanted Neto to heal the generational trauma that Brown and Black incarcerated youth lived with. I think this is also why Sito came to me last night. I was feeling overwhelmed and lost, and he was trying to help me.*

*In my dream, Sito looked just as he did right before he died: tall, strong, with light-brown skin, wearing a red 49ers jersey. His straight, dark hair fell into his eyes. Sito reached for my hand. When he touched me, we were transported to an abandoned lot. It was dark outside, and the place felt eerie. We walked across the street to a field. I could see bodies of Black women. I knew they were the women in Miami whose ends Wetli had labeled "sex-cocaine deaths" but who had actually been raped and murdered by a serial killer. Some of the women were wrapped in blankets; others were nude from the waist down.*

*Sito leaned down and touched one of the women. Her eyes opened. He held out his hand to her. When their hands met, a bright light shone where they touched. The woman's spirit floated out of her body. It disappeared into the night sky. I sensed that he had somehow helped her spirit. Sito looked at me. This book would assist in such elevations, he wanted me to know.*

*Sito started jogging down the street, going somewhere urgently. I followed, jogging alongside him. We came to an intersection. It was daytime, there was a bus stop and a corner store. The red-lettered "Cup Foods" sign was unmistakable. Although I had never been to the Twin Cities, I recognized this place. We were at the intersection of Chicago Avenue and Thirty-Eighth Street in Minneapolis, Minnesota, where George Floyd was killed. I stopped and stared in shock. Sito and I stood about thirty feet away from Officer Derek Chauvin kneeling on George Floyd's neck. This image was so deeply etched in my mind, I could not believe that I was there. Then, Sito lifted his palm. A light from his hand illuminated the scene. Now, I could see that a number of floating entities were surrounding Floyd. The whole space was full of spirits. Could I do something? Could I help Floyd? I felt panicked.*

*I wanted to stay, but Sito pulled me away. I looked back regretfully at the scene, but knew I had to follow. We were in a park. I knew this place. I had come here as a kid. It was San Francisco's Golden Gate Park. We walked past a pond. Ferns, reeds, and palms lined the edge. It was night, but I knew that in the daytime, this little lake had a fountain in the middle. Families liked to picnic here. Sito stopped and pointed toward the bushes. I could make out a homeless*



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*man in a sleeping bag. Something was wrong with him. Oh no. He was dead. Sito looked at me. This man's case was important. I had missed something. Sito wanted me to see a connection between the Black women murdered by a serial killer, George Floyd, and the dead homeless man. I needed to understand how the criminalizing of Afro-Caribbean religions was tied to excited delirium.*

*The next morning, I woke up nervous. I lit a candle for Sito and thanked him for his guidance.*

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5

# Panicked

AS I CONTINUED DIGGING into Wetli's background, strange connections kept appearing. My research seemed to speed up as if it had a momentum of its own. I would come into my office at the Center for Advanced Study in the Behavioral Sciences (CASBS) at Stanford University and discover some new, odd connection between Wetli and other cases I had been studying for years.

Two days after my dream with Sito, on Saturday, October 15, 2021, I was working late at the Center. Perched atop an eastern hill and located next to Stanford's illustrious golf course, the almost twenty thousand square feet of Center grounds lie just off the famous Junipero Serra Boulevard. The thoroughfare was named after the Franciscan friar and Spanish missionary who participated in the brutal colonization of the local Indigenous people of California. Pope Francis canonized Junipero Serra in 2015, making him the first Hispanic American saint. Local Native American tribes decried the canonization as disrespectful, arguing that it maligned the Indigenous ancestors of the land who had endured colonization under Serra's influence.[1] Indeed, this offense remains, with Saint Serra's name gracing some of the most picturesque sights of Northern California.

Junipero Serra Boulevard spans the length of the volcanic rock and greenstone basalt foothills near the university. This area is known for its robust wildlife, with hungry deer, wild turkeys, dusky-footed wood rats, and even an occasional mountain lion roaming freely. Swallows and woodpeckers flutter amid the shady woodlands of California live oaks and laurel trees that give

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the setting a light and airy serenity. Locals and tourists flock to the three-and-a-half-mile Stanford Dish Hiking Trail that loops around CASBS's grounds. With its stunning views and natural wildlife, the Center is celebrated as an ideal location for scholars to write books.

Nestled on the hillside are the CASBS Fellows' studies. These small cabins are highly coveted real estate, and Fellows compete for their preference among the fifty-four available offices. Outside each cabin door is a list of former occupants, mostly famous scholars, who "lived" in the room, making up the "Ghosts in the Study," part of the charm and lore of being at CASBS. However, it truly does not matter which study you get. Every cabin, fitted with floor-to-ceiling windows that bring the surrounding area indoors, boasts an equally gorgeous view. My corner office, Study 16, looked out on the campus. The scene was an artistic panorama of woody shrubs and wildflowers. In the distance, the grassy valley of Lake Lagunita, dried up at that time, formed a carpet behind which the Hoover Clock Tower stood tall.

It was a balmy fall day. Northern California is known for its warm autumns. So, I had left my study door ajar. I was quietly reading the materials that the helpful library manager had located for me. As the afternoon sun fell behind the hill, I was engrossed in a police document. Charles Wetli's name appeared in the file as an expert on "Afro-Caribbean cults." The case involved the suspected ritualistic murder of Leroy Carter Jr., a Black homeless man in San Francisco in 1981. When I first started conducting research on the policing of Afro-Caribbean religions in 2013, I was told about this unsolved case by two retired, high-ranking police officers whom I had interviewed in San Francisco.

The coincidences kept coming. There were very few details available about the unsolved case. I decided to do a quick search to see whether anything new had turned up since I had last looked. Much of the information on the web was on crime blogs and mystery fan pages. This case had now become horror-story lore. I managed to find some early newspaper clippings in the archive, but then I came across an article for the travel platform Inside Hook that referenced two of Wetli's cases as part of an inquiry into the 1974 murder of a woman by the name of Arlis Perry, who had been raped and killed in Stanford University's Memorial Church.[2]

From my study at CASBS, I glanced up to look in the direction of Memorial Church, and I could just make out the steeple with its cross on top. Jane Stanford had the church constructed in 1893 as a tribute to her late husband, Senator Leland Stanford. It was modeled after European churches they had seen on their travels. Memorial Church was also a tribute to Leland Stan-



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ford Jr., the couple's only son, who died of typhoid fever in 1884, just shy of his sixteenth birthday.[3] The church was meant to be the center of campus. The brilliant gold of the cut-glass tesserae makes up the largest mosaic mural in America. Measuring thirty feet in height by eighty feet in width, the scene impressively reproduces artist Antonio Paoletti's painting of Christ's ascension in the New Testament. The Romanesque feel of the massive columns, rounded archways, and carved natural stone make for a striking experience.

Inside the church, the light filters through stained glass onto polished wood pews. Exquisite frescoes and ornamental woodwork make the structure feel very different from other buildings on campus. When I was an anthropology graduate student in the early 2000s, the department was located right next to "Mem Church," as it is called by students, and I have a cherished photograph from my doctoral graduation in which I and my two young sons, Neto and Pilli, stand in front of the church.

On October 12, 1974, Arlis Perry had wandered into the church to find solace. It was around ten o'clock at night, and she had been in a disagreement with her husband, Bruce Perry, who was a graduate student at the time. The next morning Perry's body was found in a frightening scene. She was lying near the altar and was nude below the waist; someone had driven an ice pick into her skull. A long altar candle jutted out of her vagina, and another was left lying between her breasts. Police were so captivated by the scene and the fears of a cult murder that they ignored the man who found her body, a campus security guard and former police officer named Stephen Crawford, who had called in Perry's death by stating, "Hey, we got a stiff here."[4]

I had already been aware that the so-called Satanic Panic of the 1980s and 1990s had effectively vilified Afro-Caribbean religions in its wake. During this period, a mass public hysteria emerged from evangelical fears and unproven conspiracies. Law enforcement agencies, evangelicals, and child psychologists were convinced that an underground network of Satanists was abusing children and murdering people. From the documents I found, it appeared that Charles Wetli had begun to make a name for himself in this circuit.

The article from Inside Hook details how DNA evidence had finally solved the so-called satanic murder of Arlis Perry. Instead of the ritualistic crime it appeared to be, it turned out that Crawford, the campus security guard who had discovered her body, was the actual murderer. Semen found on a kneeling pillow and the jeans draped over Perry's body that had been collected at the crime scene finally linked Crawford to the murder in 2018.[5] Forty-four years after her death, this DNA evidence proved that Crawford was the killer.



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There were claims that Crawford had become upset with Stanford when the police department was reorganized and he was demoted from his position as an officer. His weapon had also been taken from him after he failed psychological tests.[6] Reporter Scott Herhold, who had researched the case since the 1970s, stated that he did not believe Perry "was the intended victim."[7] Herhold argued instead that the "gruesome crime was against Stanford."[8] He suggested that Perry had simply paid the "terrible price" for Crawford's anger.[9]

Reporters speculated Stephen Crawford might have been a serial killer. He was described as "normal" and a "good guy" by neighbors,[10] and his brother was a police officer from Mountain View, California, which seemingly lent Crawford credibility.[11] In another odd coincidence, Crawford was fired from Stanford after he was found to have stolen from the university.[12] Over a number of years, Crawford took hundreds of thousands of dollars in rare books from Stanford's main library, as well as Native American artifacts and art, including a human skull, from the university's anthropology department.[13] A forged Stanford diploma was found in Crawford's home, even though he had never graduated from the university.[14]

As a military veteran, a former police officer, and a security guard on campus, Crawford knew exactly what law enforcement would focus on. The Inside Hook article suggests that Crawford had staged Perry's murder to throw the police off his scent, because he knew that police were caught up in the Satanic Panic. Some believed that Crawford had not only gotten away with Perry's murder but had also killed others.[15] Reporters detailed a few other cases that remained unsolved, including a case that Charles Wetli was involved in as a "cult expert." Between 1973 and 1974, when Crawford was on campus, at least three other unsolved murders had been committed around Stanford that had suspicious similarities to Perry's killing.[16] One of those murders had occurred on Junipero Serra Boulevard, right around the corner from where I was sitting that day.

It was not cold, but I shivered. It was mid-October, just about the anniversary of Perry's murder. I stopped reading the articles and looked out the large window. The striking view felt different now. Time had passed too quickly for comfort. I could have sworn that I had just looked up and it was bright outside. But now the sun was setting, and what had felt so tranquil suddenly seemed unnerving. I heard a noise outside my office and jerked my head toward the open door. Walking slowly to the opening, I peeked around the corner. Two deer nearby were chewing on twigs. They looked at me, ears twitching. I felt silly for being spooked. I was sure no one else was on-site that



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weekend. My husband, who was also a Fellow, had been working in his study earlier in the day, but he had left for a late afternoon meeting. I was going to rideshare my way home.

*Maybe a security guard is on the Center grounds*, I thought.

I remembered Stephen Crawford, the campus security guard who had murdered Arlis Perry, and a chill ran up the length of my body. The story had gotten to me. I knew this place too well. For me, Stanford was like a former home that I had lived in as an adolescent and then returned to as an adult. My son Pilli, now a senior there, was majoring in computer science; he had wanted to attend college here because he felt connected to it from having grown up on campus with me when I was a doctoral student. Things looked the same, yet different. I felt as though I was stirring up ghosts. My heart was racing.

As if on cue with my spine-chilling thoughts, a news story started blaring from my laptop speakers. I turned back from the doorway where I was standing; my laptop was across the room on the desk next to the large windows overlooking Mem Church. Leaving my back unguarded, I stared at my screen in disbelief. A reporter was detailing the story of how officers of the Santa Clara County Sheriff's Office had gone to serve Stephen Crawford with the warrant for his arrest.

I rushed over and started clicking through windows on my computer, trying to discover where the offending sound was coming from. I had so many open tabs on my cluttered laptop that I could not find which one was playing. The newscaster continued to recount the gruesome details of Perry's death and then Crawford's final move. In 2018, when authorities finally went to arrest him, Crawford shot and killed himself as deputies stood outside his open front door. The former campus security guard had committed suicide to evade arrest. It was all caught on the sheriff's body camera footage, which they were about to play. When I heard the pop of the gunshot on my computer, I roughly shut my laptop to stop the sound. My computer was possessed.

Panic-stricken, I grabbed my bag, threw my laptop inside, and slammed my office door. Feeling as though I was being watched and followed, I ran down the winding road from the isolated hilltop. I was terrified. I did not even take the time to open my rideshare app. My senses on alert, I looked around frantically as I ran, expecting to see someone chasing me. Afraid I was going to trip and fall on the bumpy road, I finally arrived at the closed gate, gasping for air. The gate was supposed to be a comfort, it was supposed to reassure me that no one without clearance was allowed on these grounds after business hours.

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But I now knew that security clearance had not protected Arlis Perry or the others who had been raped and murdered on this campus. I never worked alone at CASBS again.

* * *

On February 8, 1981, Leroy Carter Jr., a Black American homeless man, was found decapitated in Golden Gate Park, San Francisco. Carter was a twenty-nine-year-old Vietnam veteran who was known to spend time in the park but who did not get into much trouble.[17] Carter's body had been found wrapped in a sleeping bag in a woodsy area near Alvord Lake, a man-made pond built in 1833, about two hundred feet west of the Stanyan and Height Street entrance.[18] A mutilated chicken was found nearby.[19] One of the odd elements of the crime was that the wing of the chicken, along with some corn kernels, had been stuffed into the bloody stump of Carter's neck, where the head had been removed.[20] I was first told of Carter's gruesome story by two retired police detectives I had interviewed early in my research on the criminalization of Afro-Cuban religions. They told me this story to explain why, for them, "Santeria" was a "type of crime." Nine years later, I came across this story again as part of the Satanic Panic scare. Arlis Perry's and Leroy Carter Jr.'s murders were seen as examples of the Bay Area's ritualistic crime phenomenon.

In 1981, Officer Sandi Gallant was called to investigate the Leroy Carter Jr. homicide. Gallant recalls not knowing where to start with the bizarre case. She had heard that Charles Wetli was an expert on Afro-Caribbean "cults," and so she reached out to him.[21] Even though at the time, Wetli had very little knowledge of Afro-Cuban religions, he concocted what now seems a fantastical tale.[22] Wetli told Officer Gallant that Leroy Carter Jr.'s killer or killers were most likely practitioners of Afro-Cuban Santeria or Palo Monte.[23]

Despite the absence of any support for the assertion that Santeria or Palo Monte was responsible for this murder, Wetli informed Gallant that the perpetrators would first boil the victim's head to create a potion. He then claimed they would consume this concoction in order to gain magical powers.[24] According to Wetli, "the ritual called for a 21-day period of brewing in a cauldron. After that, the priest would sleep in the same room as the head and the cauldron for 21 more days, ostensibly to connect with them. After this 42-day period, the final step of the ritual would be to return the head to the body's final resting place."[25]

The theory was met mostly with skepticism by the San Francisco Police Department. They did not stake out the park on the forty-second day. How-



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ever, Officer Gallant and her partner did decide to walk through the park on the morning of the forty-third day. To their astonishment, Leroy Carter Jr.'s missing head turned up near Alvord Lake. Although they never captured the person (or people) who killed him, the infamy of the story would live on to haunt Santeria and Palo Monte practices for decades.[26]

* * *

Leroy Carter Jr.'s unsolved murder remains a mystery to law enforcement and internet sleuths. One crime blog theorized that Charles Wetli himself might be the killer but that he lived too far away for it to be likely.[27] The blogger claimed that the level of detail Wetli knew about the crime was uncanny, especially the specifics about the head reappearing on the forty-second day. At the time, the only people who knew of Wetli's forty-two-day theory were the police. While it may seem far-fetched that someone from law enforcement would be involved in this murder, we need only look to the Arlis Perry murder for an example of a crime in which a former police officer had staged the scene to appear ritualistic.[28] So it is not completely implausible that Carter's murderer might have been someone connected to law enforcement.

We will likely never know whether Leroy Carter Jr.'s murder was inspired by some kind of ritual practice, or whether the homicide was simply designed to look ritualistic in order to throw police off the scent. But we do know that none of what Wetli described is accurate—at least not according to any known Afro-Caribbean religion. In a follow-up interview with Rafael Martinez, I asked about Wetli's theory about the Leroy Carter Jr. case. Martinez had never heard the story before.

"Where did Wetli get this crazy theory?" I asked him.

"Who knows!" Martinez told me.

"But how did Wetli supposedly become an expert of Afro-Cuban religions?" I probed, hoping Martinez might know something.

"Remember, he got information from all these detectives, and some of them actually were practitioners. You know, some of the cops from the city of Miami and Miami-Dade were practitioners, but most had a lot of fear. But yeah, I have no idea where he got that from."

I remembered the police report that Rafael Martinez and Charles Wetli submitted to the Dade-Miami Criminal Justice Council in 1986, "Tattoos among Cuban (Mariel) Criminals: A Cultural Analysis." The report had been circulated among law enforcement early on during the Satanic Panic and had identified Wetli as an expert on Afro-Caribbean "cults."[29] Could that be the

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reason people in law enforcement thought Wetli was a cult expert? But the report was produced five years *after* Carter's death.

Martinez recounted an unexpected visit by Wetli to his home in 1980. On that day, Wetli arrived to take Martinez to meet a Palo Monte priest. Together they, along with a police officer, went to interview the priest. The *palero*, a practitioner of Palo Monte, had undertaken a sacred promise to his beloved *nganga* spirit, committing to sleep alongside it for the entire forty nights of Lent. In Palo Monte religious traditions, the *nganga* is a spirit dwelling—often taking the form of a cauldron—that holds the sacred source of ancestral power. Unfortunately, the *nganga* has been unjustly stigmatized as malevolent. Recall that traditionally, from its Congolese heritage, the *nganga*, or *prenda*, serves as the repository for the remains of deceased family members. Through the *nganga*, a spirit is enlivened, given a tangible form, and imbued with potent abilities to offer guidance to the living.

Martinez fondly remembers a pleasant conversation with the *palero* in his home. The *palero* was hospitable and willingly shared insights, aiming to provide law enforcement officers with a deeper understanding of the religion. He expressed the hope that by engaging with them, law enforcement might cease its unwarranted criminalization of Palo Monte. It's worth noting that this interview took place in the year preceding Leroy Carter Jr.'s tragic murder in 1981.

Martinez was surprised that Wetli did not reach out to him when Sandi Gallant inquired about the case. If he had, Martinez would have told Wetli that whoever killed Carter did not exhibit behaviors consistent with Palo Monte or Santeria practitioners.

"I don't know where he got that from," Martinez remarked of Wetli's unfounded theory. Wetli's notion that the murderer would sleep with Leroy Carter Jr.'s head might have been loosely inspired by the visit to the *palero*, who had undertaken a forty-night ritual sleeping next to his *nganga*. However, from Martinez's perspective, it was evident that *paleros* were not murderers. In Palo Monte, for instance, ancestral bones are part of the sacred vessels used to reactivate spirits, but these bones are most often obtained with consent from family members before they pass away or legally through medical supply companies—not through homicidal means.

Wetli seems to have drawn upon racist stereotypes surrounding Afro-Cuban religions that depict practitioners as "Black witches" (*negros brujos*).[30] In the early years of the Cuban republic, fictional narratives circulated that propagated the false idea that Black witches were boogeymen who would murder White Cuban children, serving the dual purpose of criminalizing



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Black Cubans and scaring children into obedience.[31] Historian Ivor Miller has revealed the deep-seated racial prejudices against Black religious practitioners in Cuba throughout the "colonial, republican, and revolutionary" eras, with authorities consistently displaying hostility toward them.[32] Similar to the Jim Crow South, where unfounded fears about protecting White women served as pretext for violence against Black people, in Cuba many African and Afro-Cuban men faced executions and lynching based on these myths. Afro-Cubans were unjustly characterized as "hypersexual, criminal, and degenerate," a portrayal that aimed to reinforce White male dominance and exert control over the nation's identity.[33]

An egregious example of these baseless claims occurred in March 1875, when the Abakuá society was banned in Cuba on the grounds of claims that they were murdering White children for their blood.[34] The fires were fueled after the November 1904 kidnapping and murder of Zoila, a four-year-old White girl from the outskirts of Havana, which became a national spectacle.[35] For a year, the reporter Eduardo Varela Zequiera convinced the public that Black witchcraft (*brujería*) was to blame. Through his alarmist reporting and demands that police search the household of every Black "witch" in town, he made a successful career for himself.[36]

Without any substantiating evidence, two Black men—Lucumi Domingo Boucourt, originally from Africa, and Victor Molina, a Cuban native—were charged with Zoila's murder. Testimonies from White men claimed that there were rumors suggesting Boucourt was a renowned *brujo*, but the only evidence they had was his African origins.[37] It is important to note that Boucourt resided more than forty-five miles away from the location of Zoila's murder.[38] Following a biased trial in January 1906, both men were subjected to garroting, a form of execution by strangulation with an iron collar or wire. Their brains were preserved for what was presented as a scientific examination of Black witches, purportedly carried out to protect the White population.[39]

Martinez informed me that such stories from Cuba followed Afro-Cuban religions to the United States. After his collaboration with Charles Wetli, he grew frustrated with the discriminatory portrayal of Afro-Caribbean religions to which his and Wetli's work had contributed. "You remember, as a medical examiner, he [Wetli] had a lot of cops that came to him during the investigation of homicides," Martinez told me.

Martinez cited anecdotes shared by Miami police officers as contributing to Wetli's misunderstandings. He emphasized that these anecdotes were rooted in fear and tried to rectify these misconceptions. However, it was

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challenging; Wetli held a senior position as a medical examiner and doctor, and he wielded significant influence in the law enforcement community.

"What are some of the fears they had around Afro-Cuban religions?" I asked Martinez.

"Don't go out on December 4th," he said, referring to the day that the patron saint Santa Barbara is honored, "because they're gonna kidnap you and drink your blood because, Santa Barbara." He described these as "boogeyman-type" stories propagated by certain zealot cops. He thought Wetli was unduly influenced by this, believing these biased stories to be fact. Martinez recalled that in the first article they coauthored, Wetli had confused Santeria with Palo Monte, and "even called it voodoo." Martinez recalled thinking, "What are you doing?" But he told me that he "never had a chance to correct him."

Martinez cautioned against officers who saw supernatural threats everywhere: "You know, those cult cops. They see the devil all over the place."

I recalled encountering a news story I had found featuring Wetli and his disturbing collection in the *Burlington (VT) Daily Times*, published June 25, 1980, a year before Leroy Carter Jr.'s death. The images portrayed Wetli sitting at an evidence table in the Dade County medical examiner's office alongside a large, ghastly looking human skull in the center. In another photo, Wetli points to different items on the table as he sits next to a White woman, likely another medical examiner. A stark white tablecloth lies coldly underneath the various Afro-Cuban religious items that Wetli had supposedly "discovered," as if from an archaeological dig. The caption, headlined "SANTERIA FINDINGS," reads as follows:

> Drs. Donna Brown and Charles Wetli display the crumbling bones of a woman long dead and the remains of several types of birds (R) in the Dade County medical examiner's office Tuesday after the bones were found in Miami, Fla., cemetery this weekend. The findings are signs that Santeria—a voodoo-like cult mixing primitive African beliefs and Catholicism—is flourishing in Dade County. *Wetli is a self-taught santeria expert*.[40]

These early images circulated widely across the country; I found reprints in newspapers as far away as Texas, California, New England, and New York. There was even a *Roving Report* television episode titled "Santeria or Cuban Occult in Miami, Florida" that aired on Britain's Independent Television Network (ITN) in 1981, which featured Wetli and his gruesome collection.[41] This was during the early years of the Satanic Panic. This press identified Wetli as a



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"self-taught" expert of Santeria! Officer Gallant must have seen these stories, and she must have contacted Wetli. I was sure this media was key to how he had become known as a cult expert, even when he had no real knowledge about the religions themselves. He used the publicity surrounding his Santeria collection as a means to criminalize Afro-Cuban religions and to make himself into a so-called expert.

The *Daily Times* article quotes Wetli making sensational and erroneous statements about Afro-Caribbean religions, including claims about the use of "animal remains" for "white magic" and human bones for "black magic." Wetli states, inaccurately, that the human remains "could have been a grave robbing, it could have been a murder, or it could have been a completely legal sale of the bones."[42] To anyone with an understanding of these religions, Wetli's statements are undeniably misinformed because these religions honor human life and revere ancestral remains. Yet, alarmingly, they found acceptance among both law enforcement personnel and the general public.

I realized that a central aspect of Wetli's strategy to bolster his own authority was his reliance on deeply entrenched racial biases that many people mistakenly accepted as undeniable truths. He exploited deeply ingrained racist stereotypes associated with Afro-Cuban religions, mirroring the tactics he would later employ to perpetuate racist stereotypes against Black people, thereby fabricating the concept of excited delirium syndrome.

The extensive dissemination of these images through national media outlets transformed a young Wetli into a highly sought-after authority in his field. Six years later, he replicated this approach with his "cocaine-sex" cases, endeavoring to convince the public that the deaths of Black women were not the results of a serial killer. He employed a similar method in the 2000s, crafting the narrative of excited delirium syndrome. Through this repetitive pattern, Wetli strategically utilized media sensationalism to establish himself as an "expert."

Rafael Martinez shared his perspective, suggesting that this phenomenon was part of the broader context of the Satanic Panic. "You know, Santeria and Palo got sucked into it," he told me. "Same as all the other pagan religions. They were sucked into it as if they were evil, malevolent. 'Watch out,' you know, like they're gonna kidnap your kids."

"Let me tell you," Martinez continued, "I was invited to a couple of conferences where those people actually were speakers, and I think they were disappointed after they heard me. Because they thought I was gonna go there and say, 'Let's go hunt these people,' and then when they heard my anthropological take on these practices, they were like, 'Who is this guy?'"



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JOURNAL ENTRY

## Wednesday, March 16, 2022
Stanford, California

*The high-tech conference room at the CASBS, with its wood paneling and wall of windows, captured the natural beauty of the grounds. Today, however, the room felt especially intimidating. All Fellows give a thirty-minute "seminar" on their work, followed by thirty minutes of questions and answers. What had begun as friendly weekly presentations had become increasingly tense. When scholars who worked on race, gender, inequality, or power (mostly Fellows of color) asked questions, we were met with incredulity. Answers ranged from reinforcing racist stereotypes about people in Africa or Asia to not engaging with the questions at all.*

*Dealing with this tension during the ongoing COVID-19 global pandemic, as we underwent weekly testing to be on campus and were caught in cycles of sickness, everyone was at their worst. After almost two years of exclusively online exchanges, many of us were not accustomed to being around other people, especially not large groups.*

*I was mic'd up and had my presentation cued. I had decided to present on excited delirium syndrome and deliberately chose to include how dead spirits had led me to this discovery. I titled the talk "The Dead Lead the Way: Excited Delirium and the Policing of Afro-Latiné Religions."*

*I talked about how Afro-Latiné practitioners were drawing on alternative frames to fight against police violence. I discussed how my interactions with Jade*

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*Ellis and her father's spirit, Jeremy, have been key moments that unexpectedly shifted my research.*

*I asked: "What would it do to the research process if we took seriously Afro-Latiné religious practitioners' active engagements with the dead?" Might it call for a shift in our social scientific methods and also ourselves? I challenged that it would disrupt the racial laboratory to acknowledge the presence of dead spirits and other immaterial copresences as research interlocutors.*

*When I finished my talk, the room was eerily quiet. The first two questions came from Black scholars who wanted to hear more about how I was thinking through the idea of the "racial laboratory." I discussed how I was inspired by the work of Christina Sharpe, who talks about the slave ship as a "floating laboratory," where doctors and medical researchers took "advantage of high mortality rates to identify a bewildering number of symptoms, classify them into diseases and hypothesize about their causes."[1] Building on this racial science, medical examiners have experimented on Black and Brown bodies, offering findings that reinforce White supremacy and launch their own careers as experts.*

*A famed Latino economist applauded the "bravery" it took to admit that I encountered spirits. He challenged me to go deeper, to look at other spirits, besides Jeremy's, with whom I have been working all along. He suggested I add my own story into the book. He was addressing the bravery it takes to confront Western positivism. Positivism is a self-reinforcing worldview that holds that "truth" can be determined only by verifiable science, empirically based evidence, or mathematical calculations.[2] Positivism has such a powerful hold on truth claims that non-Western cultural perspectives are always diminished as fanciful "beliefs." Even anthropologists who claim to deeply submerge themselves in other cultural formations are unable to acknowledge or admit to engagements with spiritual entities without being dismissed as having "gone native." I argued that it is time that we decolonize our methods to take spirits as seriously as the people we work with do. If we do not, how can social scientists truly claim to have a deep understanding of non-White, non-Western perspectives?*

*Then, a White woman, a philosopher, commented, "I'm sympathetic to alternative epistemologies, and I'm sympathetic with decolonizing knowledge, but what I struggle with in so many ways is spirituality." This incredulousness has come from her mother's Christianity, she said: "So this is a question if you can help me get along with my mom?" When her mother says, "You were safe because I prayed for you," the philosopher responds, "How many other mothers are praying for their daughters who aren't safe?" She asked me how I can reconcile this problem with my decolonial theory of spirits.*



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*I explained that in Afro-Latiné understandings, spiritual impact on the world is not as physically dense as touching and moving an object. Instead, we must think through spiritual effects as vibrational influences. Many people and places are haunted. And not all spirits have the same level of impact on the material world. There are precise techniques that enable the dead to access more agency. Jeremy, for example, became activated through Jade's healing techniques. Some entities do have direct impact without intervention, as, for example, in the countless hauntings known throughout time, or in near-death experiences in which people encounter deceased family members as they pass.*

*This series of fruitful questions gave me hope. People were taking the idea of spirits seriously and not just dismissing my assertions out of hand. Then, a scientist raised his hand. "I'm on Einstein's side of this," he said, referencing the popular opinion that famed physicist Albert Einstein had once attempted a séance with his friend, the well-known author Upton Sinclair, and that Einstein dismissed spiritualism as "nonsense."*

*"Most of your talk was describing things that require no spirits," he told me. "You are entirely persuasive. I can see how the experiences, practices, and techniques are wholly real, effective, and evidence of the phenomenon you are talking about—spirits coming from the other side and influencing action, you know, changing people's physical . . . [having] a material impact on the world. But most of your talk was describing things that require no spirits. You could describe excited delirium as a cover for police violence without ever invoking anyone's parents. So, I'm curious, you know, how you deal with the obvious criticism from an old, cis, White empiricist, who says the story you tell is incredibly powerful and important, but the explanatory apparatus is unswallowable for me."*

*I wish I would have responded to him that excited delirium gets its origins from the assault on Afro-Latiné religions. Instead, what I told him seemed to come out of nowhere. I leaned into the microphone and said, "Well, when you go to sleep at night, maybe the spirits will talk to you themselves."*

*I chuckled almost involuntarily before composing myself. Then I continued with my original response: "I can offer a method that stems from a decolonial approach that is grounded in an alternative epistemology, and I'll find people who disagree with this method. But I'm not going to convince you against your Western skepticism. That is something that is inherently tied to the anti-Black racism that I have been describing throughout the talk."*

*After the talk, I was frustrated. The question referencing Einstein still bothers me now as I write down my thoughts. I did not see the scientist for the rest of the day, so we could not continue the conversation. But I wanted to say more.*



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*Later that day, one of the Fellows, an African philosopher, thanked me for taking African understandings of spirits seriously. She said that she had never heard anyone talk about African notions of spirit presence as truth in an academic setting until my talk, and it made her feel validated. That alone made my talk worthwhile.*

*Leaving* CASBS, *I thought to myself, How does anyone deal with the horrors of police violence without being able to pray?*

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